The Accessibility Paradox: Platform Standardisation and the Legitimacy of Play

Jack Burnett
Bristol Interaction Group
University of Bristol
Bristol, United Kingdom
jack.burnett@bristol.ac.uk

Abstract

Platform standardisation improves accessibility across contemporary gaming ecosystems, but it also shapes which forms of accessible play are recognised as legitimate. This Perspectives on Play paper introduces the accessibility paradox of platform standardisation: the same infrastructures that support accessibility can constrain adaptation and community-led solutions. I argue that accessibility is not solely a technical challenge but also a question of authority, legitimacy, and governance.

CCS Concepts

• **Applied computing** → **Computer games**; • **Human-centered computing** → **Accessibility technologies**.

Keywords

Accessibility, Platformisation, Standardisation, Game Accessibility

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1 Introduction

Modern gaming platforms are increasingly defined by standardisation and platformisation [10, 34], allowing developers to create predictable player experiences without needing to account for specific hardware architectures [10], input devices [32], or accessibility guidelines [30]. By reducing technical fragmentation and promoting consistency across devices and platforms [2, 34], standardisation has become a defining feature of contemporary game development, making it more accessible with lower technical barriers. Shared standards establish baseline expectations for interaction and accessibility [15, 30], but they also influence which forms of play and accessibility are recognised and supported.

Accessibility is often framed as a technical challenge of accommodating diverse needs [50]; however, it is also shaped by infrastructures that influence which solutions are supported [10]. Gamers may rely on customised controllers to access play, only for platform policy changes to render them unusable [16, 26]. Players' accessibility needs may remain unchanged, but the legitimacy of their solutions does not, reflecting a broader shift in gaming in which platform standards increasingly shape what accessibility looks like in practice. As accessibility becomes embedded within platform infrastructures, authority over accessible play shifts from players towards platform holders [8, 28].

I argue that this creates an accessibility paradox of platform standardisation: the mechanisms designed to increase accessibility through consistency and predictability can simultaneously create accessibility barriers by limiting the flexibility and adaptations on which many disabled players rely [3, 21, 29]. Standardisation improves access by establishing baseline guarantees of participation, yet accessibility often depends on departures from those expectations as they embed assumptions about legitimate interaction and acceptable forms of play [19, 23]. This paradox extends CHI PLAY research on accessible play beyond how access is designed [11, 42, 43] to ask who gets to recognise and permit it.

2 The Promise of Standardisation

Standardisation has become a defining characteristic of modern gaming platforms, shaping how interaction is designed and experienced [10, 34]. Shared control schemes [32], interface conventions [25], hardware specifications [10], and accessibility frameworks [30] establish a baseline of consistency across games and services.

For developers, standardisation reduces technical complexity and development costs by providing shared infrastructures for building and deploying games across platform ecosystems [10, 38]. Software development kits structure how experiences are implemented within platform ecosystems, enabling consistent interaction patterns across titles [4, 31], while certification processes ensure compliance with platform-level expectations for inputs and functionality [34, 36]. Accessibility guidelines [15, 30] formalise baseline expectations, including remappable controls, subtitle systems, and compatibility with assistive technologies. These infrastructures reduce fragmentation by allowing developers to build on shared technical foundations rather than bespoke system integrations.

Competitive integrity motivates standardisation [46], particularly in multiplayer contexts where fairness is negotiated through balancing and assistance mechanisms [1, 18], while relying on consistent input interpretation and predictable system behaviour [13, 24]; however, these constraints can disproportionately impact gamers with disabilities [16, 34].



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3 When Standards Become Governance

The tension between accessibility and standardisation is not simply technical but political. Accessibility concerns accommodating diverse forms of participation [50], while standardisation often assumes a "standard" player who exhibits only minor deviations from expected modes of interaction [40]. In practice, player needs are dynamic and vary considerably across contexts, from physical to cognitive, and depend on situational factors of use [17, 49].

Accessibility settings often allow for customisation, but this is typically confined within boundaries established by the platform [33]. As a result, players who require unconventional control schemes or alternative input configurations may be unintentionally excluded when platform standards or certification requirements do not recognise non-standard interaction patterns [7, 16, 45], particularly in contexts where competitive integrity and standards adherence prioritise uniform input behaviour and may not differentiate between assistive and exploitative interaction patterns [47].

Over-standardisation does more than constrain experimentation; it increasingly determines who is permitted to experiment in the first place. As accessibility becomes embedded within platform standards through certification processes [36] and compliance requirements [34], the boundaries of acceptable interaction become increasingly tied to platform-defined expectations of how games should be played [10]. Developers may be discouraged from pursuing unconventional accessibility solutions when these challenge or fall outside approved pathways [5, 36]. Therefore, accessibility becomes shaped not only by what players need, but by what platforms are prepared to recognise and support. The question becomes not only what accessibility solutions are possible, but which are considered legitimate.

4 Who Decides What Counts as Accessibility?

Accessibility is often discussed as a question of provision [39, 50]. Yet accessibility solutions matter only insofar as players are permitted to use them. When accessibility is understood as an ongoing condition of play rather than a static set of features [9], questions of who determines which forms of access are recognised become increasingly important.

At the centre of this structure is a chain of reliance. Players depend on developers to implement accessibility features that reflect their needs [8], while developers depend on platform holders for the enabling tools and infrastructures for those features [28]. By defining technical requirements and supported interactions [10, 36], platform holders influence the range of accessible solutions that can be implemented within their ecosystems. As accessibility becomes mediated through these layers of dependence, accessible play decisions move further away from the players who rely on them.

The lived practices of adaptive and assistive play make this dependency visible. In work with players developing custom controllers and accessibility configurations, accessibility becomes a continual negotiation with systems that determine which devices and interactions are recognised, rather than simply selecting the most effective solution for a player's needs; for example, Sony's restriction of PS5 games to DualSense-compatible controllers created barriers for players who relied on customised PS4-based accessibility setups [26]. Similarly, a controller setup that works reliably in one game may fail entirely in another due to differences in platform and engine-level implementations rather than player intent or ability [6, 29]. Accessibility becomes dependent on continued system compatibility beyond a player's control, as platform infrastructures govern which forms of accessibility are easier to recognise, support, and legitimise than others. Platform updates, certification changes, and policy decisions can render previously functional accessibility configurations unstable or unusable, requiring ongoing adaptation simply to maintain access to play [7, 16, 26].

Yet accessibility has never emerged solely from platforms or developers. Players and communities frequently develop strategies that extend accessibility beyond formal platform pathways [3, 21, 29], despite the risk of account penalties or bans [22, 48]. These practices demonstrate that accessibility remains a distributed and participatory process rather than a platform-defined feature set. Authority is central to accessibility, determining both what forms of play are possible and which forms of interaction are considered legitimate.

5 Standardisation as a Minimum Guarantee

The solution is not to abandon standardisation. Modern gaming ecosystems depend on shared standards to support usability, security, and competitive integrity [10, 34, 46]. The problem arises when standards are treated as complete solutions to accessibility rather than baseline guarantees of participation. Accessibility concerns human diversity, and no standard can fully anticipate the range of abilities, preferences, technologies, or even contexts through which people engage with play [14, 50]. Standardisation should therefore be understood as a minimum guarantee of play, as a foundation that establishes reliable access without defining the limits of legitimate interaction.

Accessibility has historically emerged through adaptation rather than standardisation alone [3, 21, 29, 44], with players with disabilities [35], community groups [37], assistive technology creators [51], modders [20], and developers [41] continually developing new ways of overcoming barriers that formal accessibility frameworks could not fully anticipate; these practices demonstrate that expertise in accessible play is distributed across gaming ecosystems rather than residing solely in platform standards. Standards are most valuable when they support this process by providing a stable foundation for accessibility innovation rather than defining the boundaries of accessible play.

This perspective reframes accessibility as a democratic and participatory process that challenges the concentration of authority within platform certification systems and proprietary infrastructures. Players with disabilities are active contributors to accessible play through adaptation and community-led innovation. If accessibility is understood as an ongoing condition of play rather than a fixed set of platform features, then players and communities must have a greater role in shaping how accessibility is recognised, supported, and maintained within gaming ecosystems [12, 27].

Standards remain necessary for addressing behaviours that can threaten competitive integrity and system stability; however, their role should be to regulate harm rather than enforce uniformity.

There is no standard player, only diverse and changing forms of participation. Accessibility is best supported when standards establish a floor for inclusion while preserving space for adaptation and innovation. The future challenge is therefore who gets to define accessibility, and how authority over accessible play is shared between platforms, developers, players, and communities.

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